

5.1 Operating Systems For Mobile Phones

Operating systems for mobile phones can be classified into the proprietary and open-standard categories. Symbian is an open-standard OS, not to be confused with open source. An open OS can address the diversity in phone hardware, and it can also handle changing market needs. Phone manufacturers can buy the license for such an OS to freely implement phone-specific changes. Proprietary OSes such as Windows Mobile are specifically designed for phones that use a specific set of hardware. Linux has also entered the mobile OS market, and was well received in China. Moreover, due to its open architecture, Linux can also be easily altered by phone manufactures to support their model-specific features.

5.1.1 The Symbian OS

Symbian, a software development and licensing company, was established in 1998 with its headquarters in the United Kingdom. The company's founder shareholders were Psion, Nokia, Matsushita (Panasonic), Ericsson and Motorola. Symbian develops and licenses the Symbian OS, an OS for data-enabled mobile phones. However, a third party provides the User Interface (UI) layer for this OS. The shareholders and licensees put together constitute a major proportion of the mobile phone manufacturers; this helped Symbian gain popularity. But that wasn't the only reason for its widespread acceptance: Symbian follows an open structure, by which the licensees can easily and at will make necessary changes and add their own UI to match their phone model's technical specifications.

The incessant increase in user requirement in a mobile phone has signalled the limits of proprietary OSes adopted by early mobile phone manufacturers. The mobile phone market is dominated by brands, and not the operating system that goes into it. People are not aware of, and are not bothered about, the OS or the amount of work done to develop it. Conversely, the user demand has brought about the change in the functioning of a mobile